Last time we introduced the question of what we should believe. We began by considering this rule of belief:

No Proof → No Belief

If you can't give a good argument for P, don't believe P.

But we saw that this led to the result that you should not believe anything at all, which seems very implausible.

At the very least, it seems, we should believe things that we can be certain of:

This is a version of a view known as **foundationalism**.

It can be summed up with the following negative rule of belief:

Certainty → Belief

If you can rule out any situation which would make P false, you should believe P.

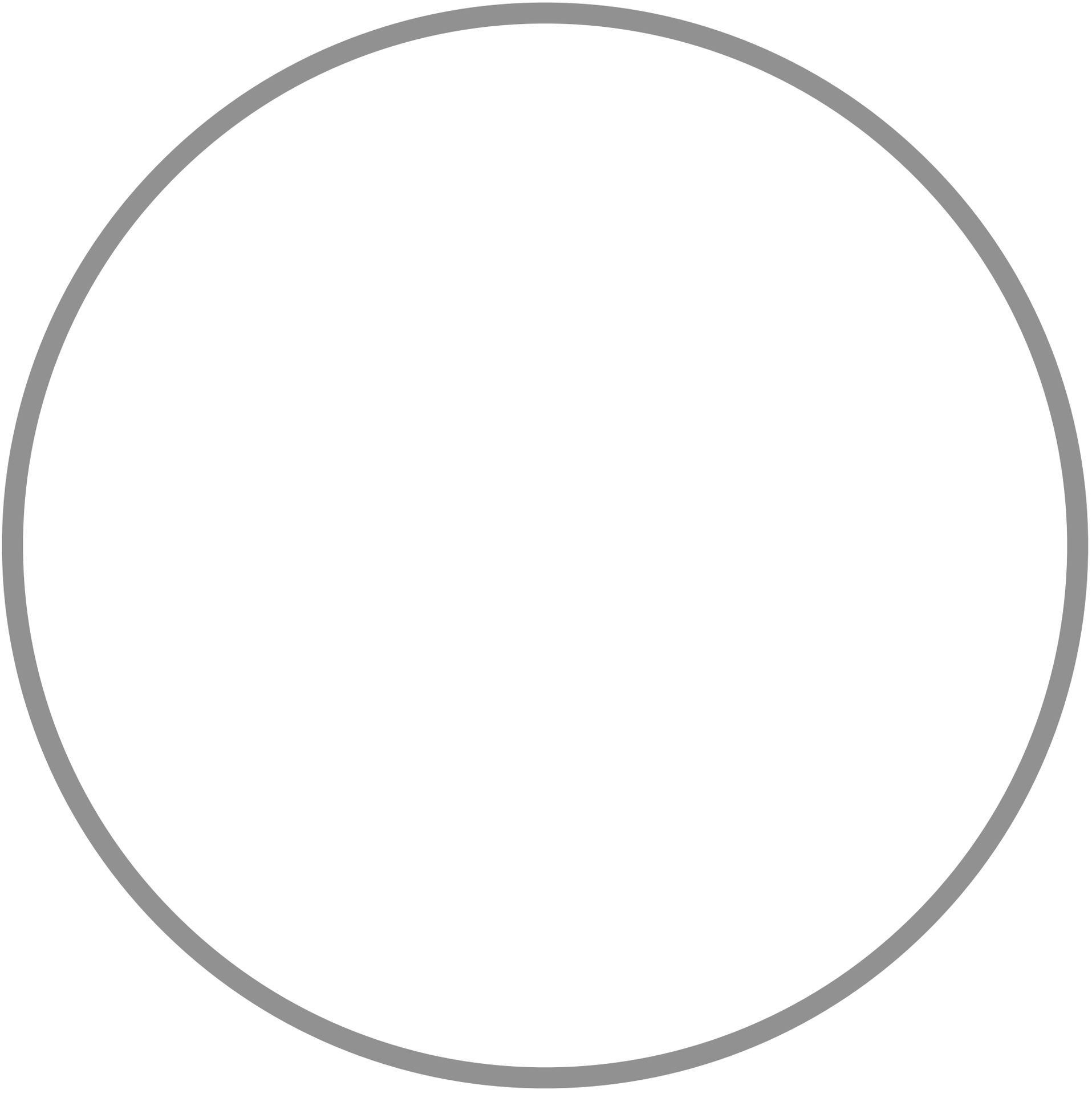
Experience → Belief

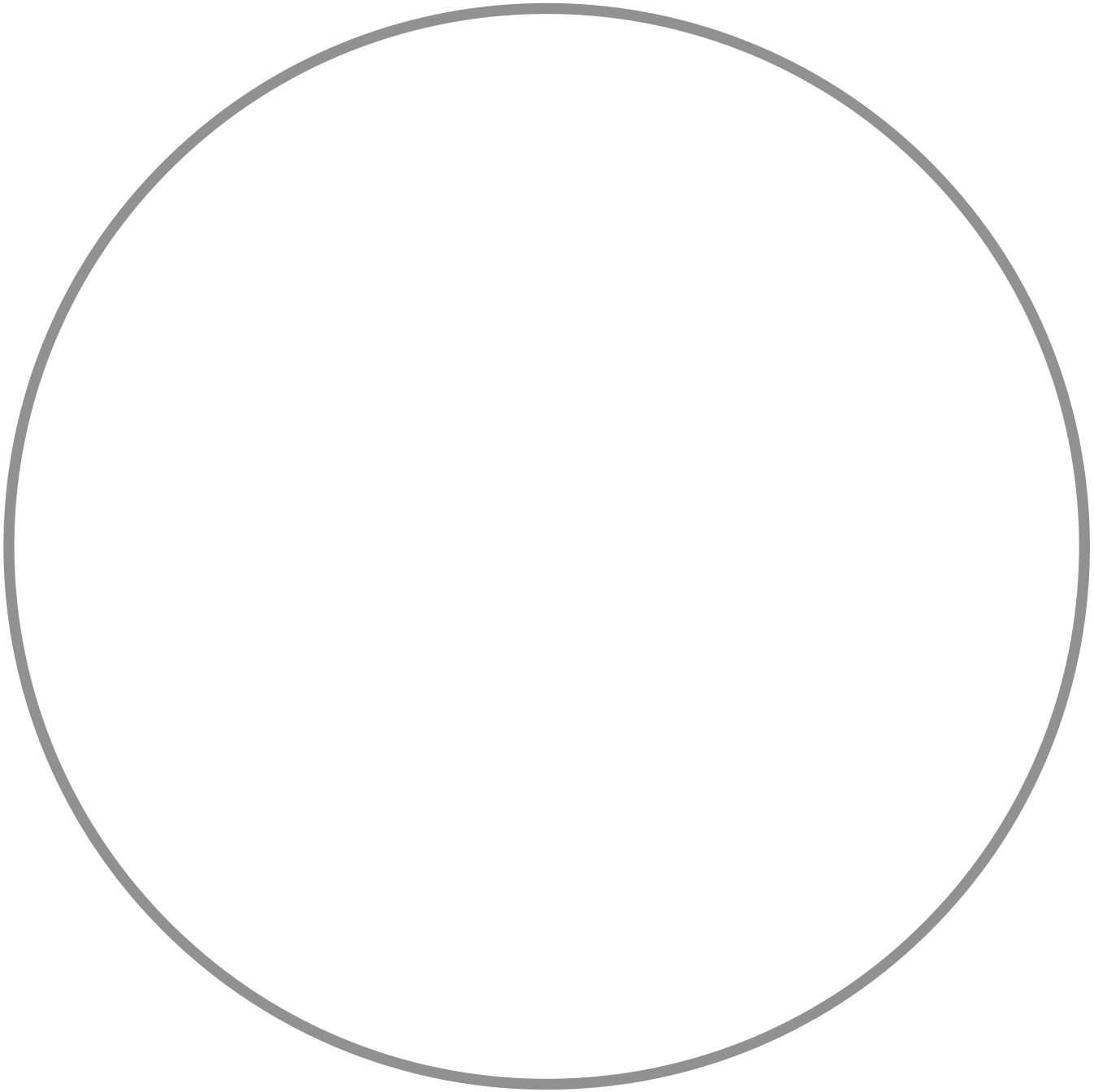
If your sense experience tells you that P, and you have no reason to think that your sense experience is misleading, you should believe P.

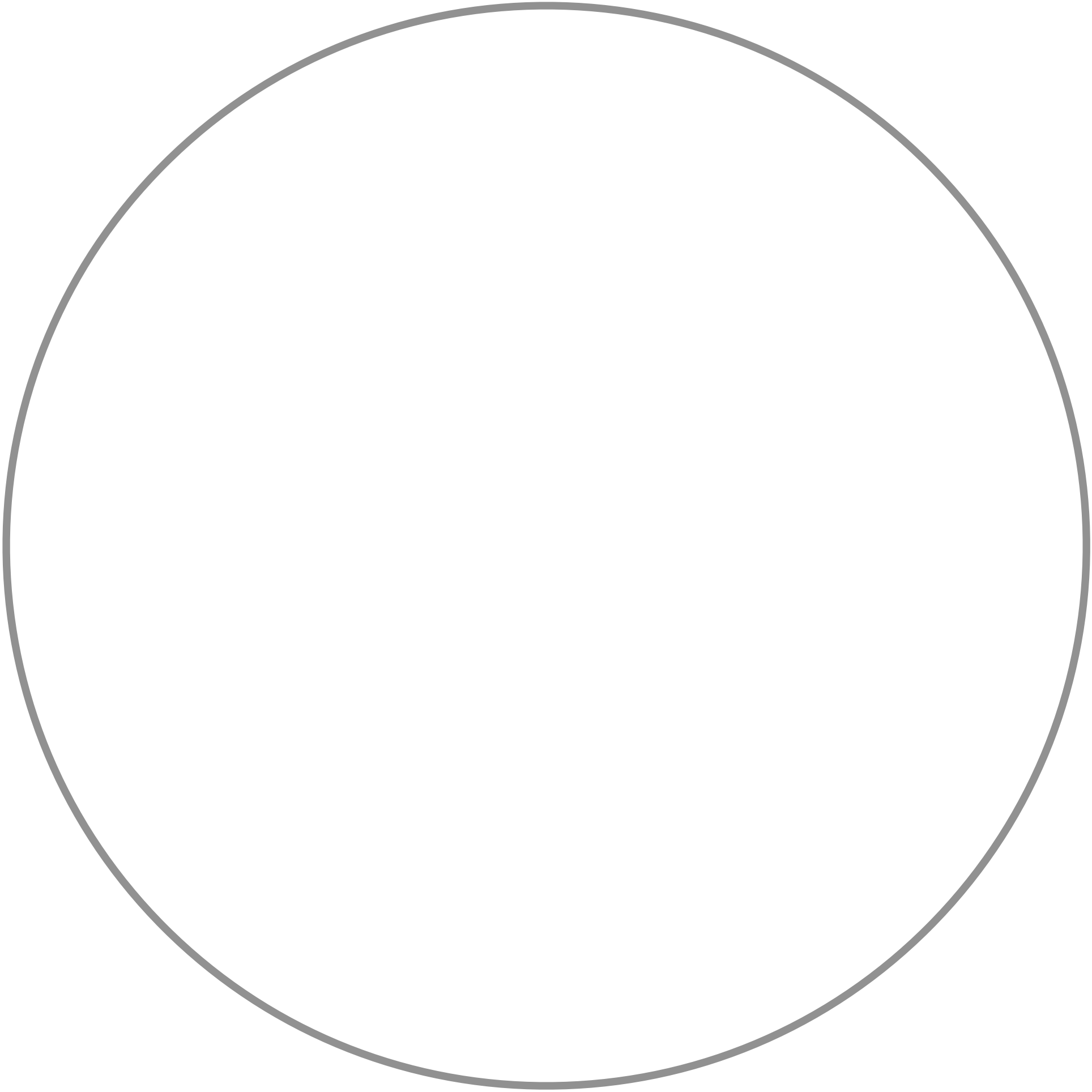
Good Argument → Belief

If there is a valid argument for P and you should believe each of that argument's premises, you should believe P.

We can compare this to some of the other negative rules of belief we have considered.



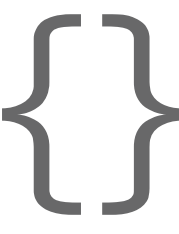




No
Foundations
→ No Belief

Doubt →
No Belief

No Good Argument → No Belief



$$2+2=4$$

I exist.

I feel cold.

I have hands.

It rained yesterday.

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Belief

argument for P and you

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No

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Foundations

Doubt →

No Belief

No Good

Argument

→ No Belief

yesterday.

It rained

believe P.

P, you should

Proof → Belief

If you can prove

and you can’t give a good

If you can’t be certain that P and

argument for P, you should not

No Foundations → No Belief

your senses don’t tell you that P

believe P.

up was in the following argument against the existence of immaterial souls:

We have encountered this idea twice already in this course. One place it came

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